ENGLISH LANGUAGE & LINGUISTICS 1A

Meaning and Structure

University of Glasgow

Change in Meaning

Marc Alexander

Week 10

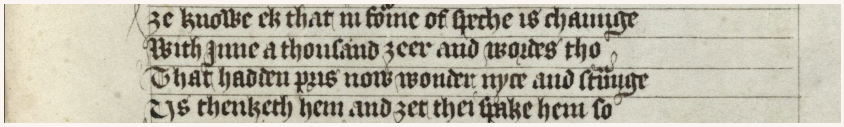
1

1400s: That peaceful serving boy made a fool out of their silly young goat's strength.

The merry knight was fond of their nice kid's craft.

Modern: The cheerful warrior liked their pleasant child's skill.

2

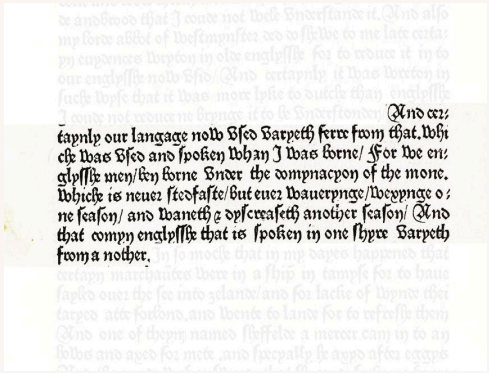


“ Ye knowe ek, that in forme of speche is chaunge
With inne a thousand yeer and wordes tho
That hadden prys, now wonder nyce and straunge
Us thinketh hem and yet thei spake hem so

[You know also that forms of speech will change
Within a thousand years, and words
That had a value, now wondrous silly and strange
We think them, they yet they spoke them so]

Chaucer, Geoffrey. c.1385. *Troilus and Criseyde*. Book II, lines 22-25.
Manuscript c. 1415-25: Cambridge, Corpus Christi College, MS 061, f. 149r

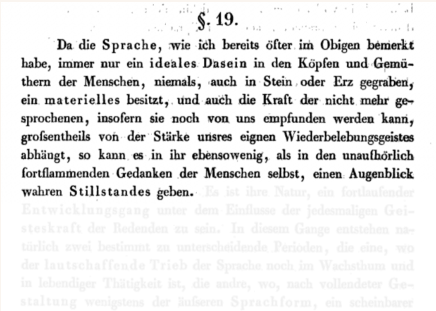
3



“ And certaynly our langage now vsed varyeth ferre from that. whiche was vsed and spoken whan I was borne / For we englysshe men / ben [are] borne vnder the domynacyon of the mone. whiche is neuer stedfaste / but euer wauerynge / wexynge one season / and waneth & dyscreaseth another season / And that comyn englisshe that is spoken in one shyre varyeth from a nother.

Prologue. Caxton, William. 1490. *Virgil's Booke of Eneydos*. London: Printed by William Caxton.

4



§. 19.

Da die Sprache, wie ich bereits öfter im Obigen bemerkt habe, immer nur ein ideales Dasein in den Köpfen und Gemüthern der Menschen, niemals, auch in Stein oder Erz gegraben, ein materielles besitzt, und auch die Kraft der nicht mehr gesprochenen, insofern sie noch von uns empfunden werden kann, grofsentheils von der Stärke unsres eignen Wiederbelebungsgeistes abhängt, so kann es in ihr ebensowenig, als in den unaufhörlich fortflammenden Gedanken der Menschen selbst, einen Augenblick wahren Stillstandes geben.

> Since language, as I have often noted above, always has only an ideal existence in the heads and minds of men, never a material one, even if engraved in stone or ore, and since the power of language that is no longer spoken, insofar as it can still be felt by us, depends largely on the strength of our own spirit of revival, there can be no moment of true standstill in it any more than in the ceaselessly flaming thoughts of men themselves.

von Humboldt, Wilhelm. 1836. *Über die Verschiedenheit des menschlichen Sprachbaues und ihren Einfluss auf die geistige Entwickelung des Menschengeschlechts* (=On the Diversity of Human Language Construction and Its Influence on the Mental Development of the Human Species). Berlin: F. Dümmler.

5

...time alters all things; there is no reason why language should escape this universal law.

des rapports: [1280] le temps altère toutes choses; il n'y a pas de raison pour que la langue échappe à cette loi universelle.

Let us simply invoke this fact that we know of no thing that does not change over time.

D 225 [suite de 1300] SM III 129
[1280] Invoquons simplement ce fait que nous ne connaissons aucune chose qui ne s'altère dans le **temps.** [suite 1301]

(Let us simply invoke the fact that) we know of no thing that does not change over time.

III C 326 [suite de 1300]
[1280] ⟨Invoquons simplement ce fait que⟩ nous ne connaissons aucune chose qui ne s'altère dans le temps. [suite 1301]

We can refer provisionally to this simple fact that any kind of thing [which is] (subject to) Time is modified...

[1280] On peut se référer provisoirement à ce simple fait que toute espèce de chose [qui est] ⟨soumise au⟩ Temps se modifie, donc que la langue ou somme de rapports []. (⟨donc que la langue = somme des rapports entre le signifiant [].⟩) [suite 1301]

de Saussure, Ferdinand. 1916. *Cours de linguistique générale*. Eds. Charles Bally & Albert Sechehaye, with Albert Riedlinger. Paris: Payot.
de Saussure, Ferdinand. 1968–1974. *Cours de linguistique générale, édition critique*. Ed. Rudolf Engler. Wiesbaden: Harrassowitz.

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Semantic Change

- **Saussure:** "[…] time alters all things; there is no reason why language should escape this universal law."
- **Sapir:** "Language moves down time in a current of its own making."
- So words naturally change their meaning; language is not a fossil
- How do words change meaning?

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1400s: The cold peasant was satisfied because her uneducated godparent looked truly skilful.

The cool villain was sad because her lewd gossip appeared very artificial.

Modern: The admirable scoundrel was sorrowful because her sexually-explicit rumours seemed intensely fake.

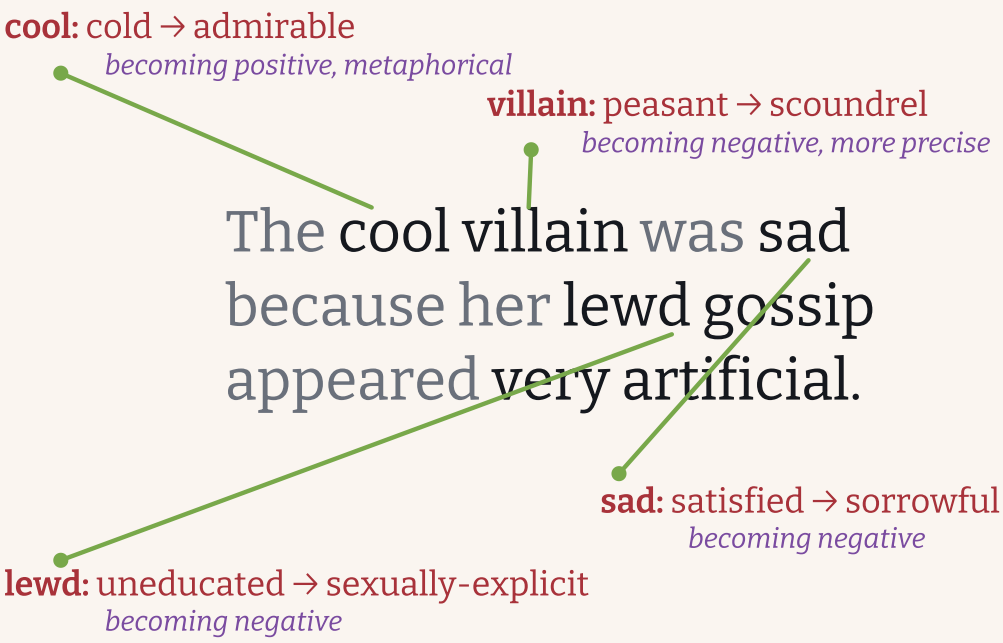
8

Semantic Changes

Semantic changes are notoriously difficult to classify or systematize [...] Additionally, semantic change is much more closely connected with change in the external, non-linguistic world, especially with developments in the spheres of culture and technology.

Durkin, Philip. 2009. *The Oxford Guide to Etymology*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. 222–3.

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Types of Semantic Change

- Becoming positive (*cool*)
- Becoming negative (*sad*)
- Becoming more general (*gossip*)
- Becoming more precise (*villain*)
- Becoming grammatical (*very*)
- Metaphor and metonymy (*cool*)

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Amelioration and Pejoration

- **Amelioration** (or elevation): more positive
  - *nice* (foolish → pleasant)
  - *sophisticated* (artificial → refined)
  - *knight* (servant → nobleman)
- **Pejoration** (or deterioration): more negative
  - *silly* (blessed → foolish)
  - *vulgar* (common → crude)
  - *wench* (child → servant)

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Case Study: *silly*

Old English	*Middle English*	*Early Modern English*	*Modern English*
happy			
fortunate			
blessed	→ pious, holy		
	innocent, harmless		
	weak, pitiable	→ simple, ignorant	
		feeble-minded	→ foolish, stupid

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Broadening and Narrowing

- **Broadening** (or widening): more general
  - *dog* (specific breed → any canine)
  - *salary* (salt payment → any payment)
  - *bird* (small birds → all avian species)
- **Narrowing** (or specialization): more precise
  - *meat* (any food → animal flesh)
  - *deer* (any animal → specific species)
  - *starve* (any death → death by hunger)

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Grammaticalization

- Grammaticalization: becoming grammatical
- More precisely: content word → function word
  - *have to* lexical possession → modal obligation
  - *while* noun meaning 'time' → subordinating conjunction
  - *like* adjective meaning 'similar' → discourse marker, quotative
  - *because* PP 'by cause' → subordinating conjunction
  - *away* OE 'on weg', PP 'on one's way' → adverb

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Metaphor and Metonymy

- Next week! Change through similarity and association:
  - *sweet* (taste → personality)
  - *sharp* (edge → intelligence)
  - *bitter* (taste → emotion)
  - *suits* (clothing → businesspeople)
  - *press* (machine → media)
- Can happen with whole domains:
  - In psychology, many physical metaphors (*depression, projection, defense, pressure, breakthrough, burnout, perspective, falling apart*)

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Chains

- Like with *silly*, these changes are often chained in complex ways:
  - *navigate* (sail a vessel → move between physical obstacles → move between figurative obstacles → use a website)
  - *awful* (inspiring awe → worthy of respect → impressive → frighteningly impressive → dreadful, monstrous → very bad)
  - *bully* (sweetheart → fine fellow → protector, champion → swaggering person → intimidator → harasser)
  - *heart* (organ → emotional centre → to love/like → like/favourite symbol → digital interaction)

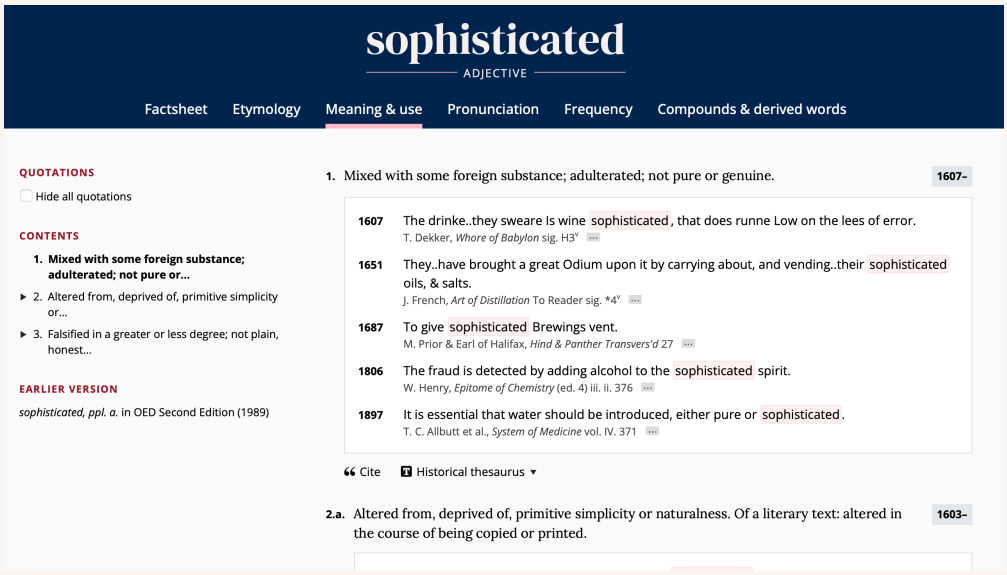
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Why do meanings change?

- *External forces* such as new things in the world shift word meanings (so *wireless* meaning 📻 *radio*, common in the early and mid twentieth century, now often means technology without cords, as in ⌨️ *wireless keyboard*)
- *Internal forces* such as metaphor, or systemic regulation (OE/ON 👗 *skirt*/ 👚 *shirt*; homonymic clash in Northern English and Scots 🫘 *neer/kidney*, 👂 *ear/lug*)

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Evidence



sophisticated

ADJECTIVE

Factsheet | Etymology | Meaning & use | Pronunciation | Frequency | Compounds & derived words

QUOTATIONS

Hide all quotations

CONTENTS

1. **Mixed with some foreign substance; adulterated; not pure or...**
2. Altered from, deprived of, primitive simplicity or...
3. Falsified in a greater or less degree; not plain, honest...

EARLIER VERSION

sophisticated, ppl. a. in OED Second Edition (1989)

1. Mixed with some foreign substance; adulterated; not pure or genuine. **1607–**

1607 The drinke..they sweare Is wine sophisticated, that does runne Low on the lees of error.
T. Dekker, *Whore of Babylon* sig. H3ᵛ

1651 They..have brought a great Odium upon it by carrying about, and vending..their sophisticated oils, & salts.
J. French, *Art of Distillation* To Reader sig. *4ᵛ

1687 To give sophisticated Brewings vent.
M. Prior & Earl of Halifax, *Hind & Panther Transvers'd* 27

1806 The fraud is detected by adding alcohol to the sophisticated spirit.
W. Henry, *Epitome of Chemistry* (ed. 4) iii. ii. 376

1897 It is essential that water should be introduced, either pure or sophisticated.
T. C. Allbutt et al., *System of Medicine* vol. IV. 371

Cite | Historical thesaurus

2.a. Altered from, deprived of, primitive simplicity or naturalness. Of a literary text: altered in the course of being copied or printed. **1603–**

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Evidence

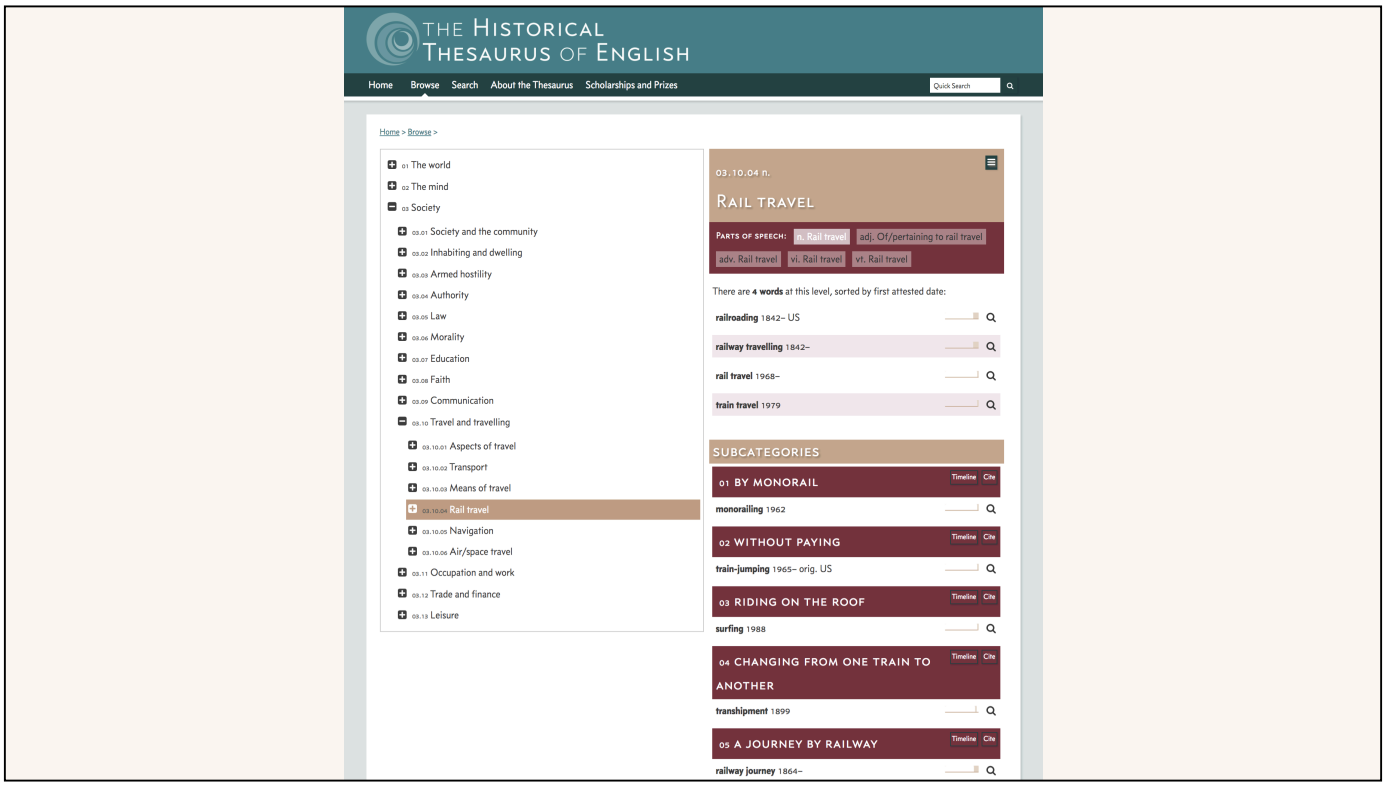
- You should use OED citations to see examples in use (remember meanings exist only in use). So:
- *naughty*, adjective
  - Having or possessing nothing; poor, needy (c.1450 ‘More nedyer and nau3tier’)
  - Having no morals; morally bad or wicked (from C15th; 1677 ‘A most vile, flagitious man, a sorry and naughty Governour as could be’)
  - Sexually provocative (from C16th; 1675 ‘the naughty Town Women, who only hate their Husbands, and love every Man else’)
  - Mischevious or disobedient (from C17th; 1889 ‘behaves like a very naughty child’)

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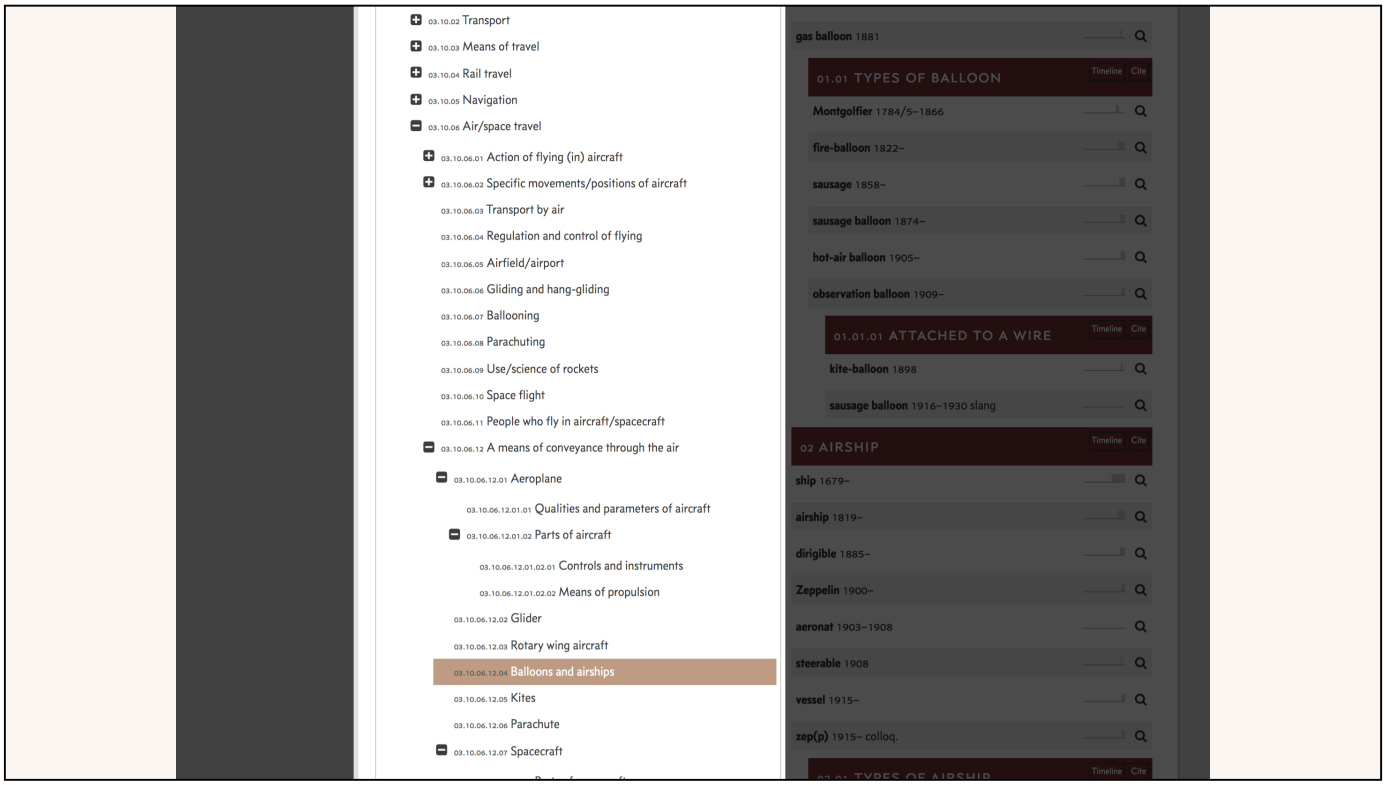
Words and meanings

- There are approximately 3.4 *forms* for each *concept*, on average, over the last millennium of English (804,830 words and 235,249 meanings).
- We know this due to the *Historical Thesaurus of English* (ht.ac.uk), a research project at Glasgow since 1965, which arranges all the word forms in English according to their meaning.
- It is ‘a magnificent achievement of quite extraordinary value. It is perhaps the single most significant tool ever devised for investigating semantic, social, and intellectual history’ (Lord Randolph Quirk).

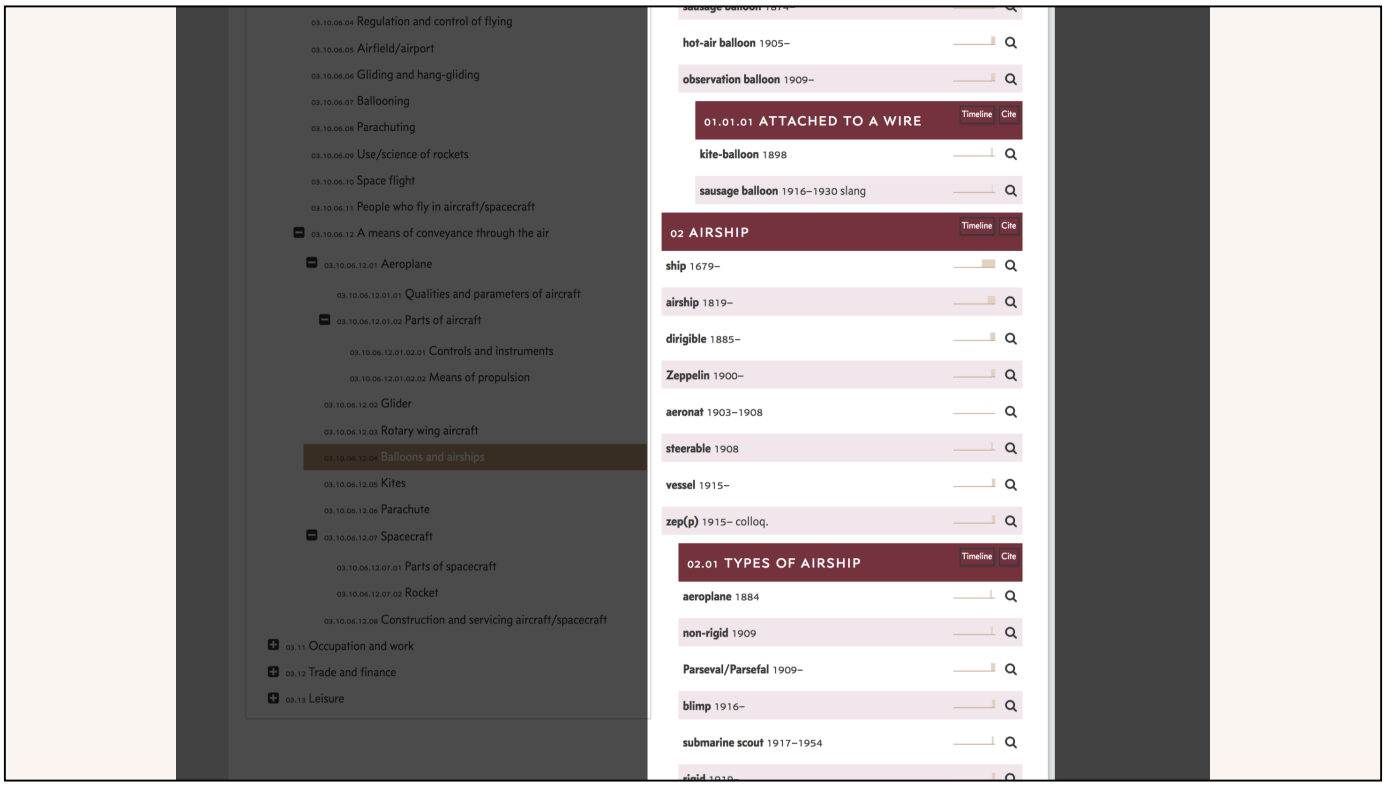
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THE HISTORICAL THESAURUS OF ENGLISH
Home
Browse
Search
About the Thesaurus
Scholarships and Prizes
Quick Search
Home > Browse >
01 The world
02 The mind
03 Society
03.01 Society and the community
03.02 Inhabiting and dwelling
03.03 Armed hostility
03.04 Authority
03.05 Law
03.06 Morality
03.07 Education
03.08 Faith
03.09 Communication
03.10 Travel and travelling
03.10.01 Aspects of travel
03.10.02 Transport
03.10.03 Means of travel
03.10.04 Rail travel
03.10.05 Navigation
03.10.06 Air/space travel
03.11 Occupation and work
03.12 Trade and finance
03.13 Leisure
03.10.04 n.
RAIL TRAVEL
PARTS OF SPEECH: n. Rail travel
adj. Of/pertaining to rail travel
adv. Rail travel
vi. Rail travel
vt. Rail travel
There are 4 words at this level, sorted by first attested date:
railroading 1842– US
railway travelling 1842–
rail travel 1968–
train travel 1979
SUBCATEGORIES
01 BY MONORAIL
Timeline
Cite
monorailing 1962
02 WITHOUT PAYING
train-jumping 1965– orig. US
03 RIDING ON THE ROOF
surfing 1988
04 CHANGING FROM ONE TRAIN TO ANOTHER
transhipment 1899
05 A JOURNEY BY RAILWAY
railway journey 1864–

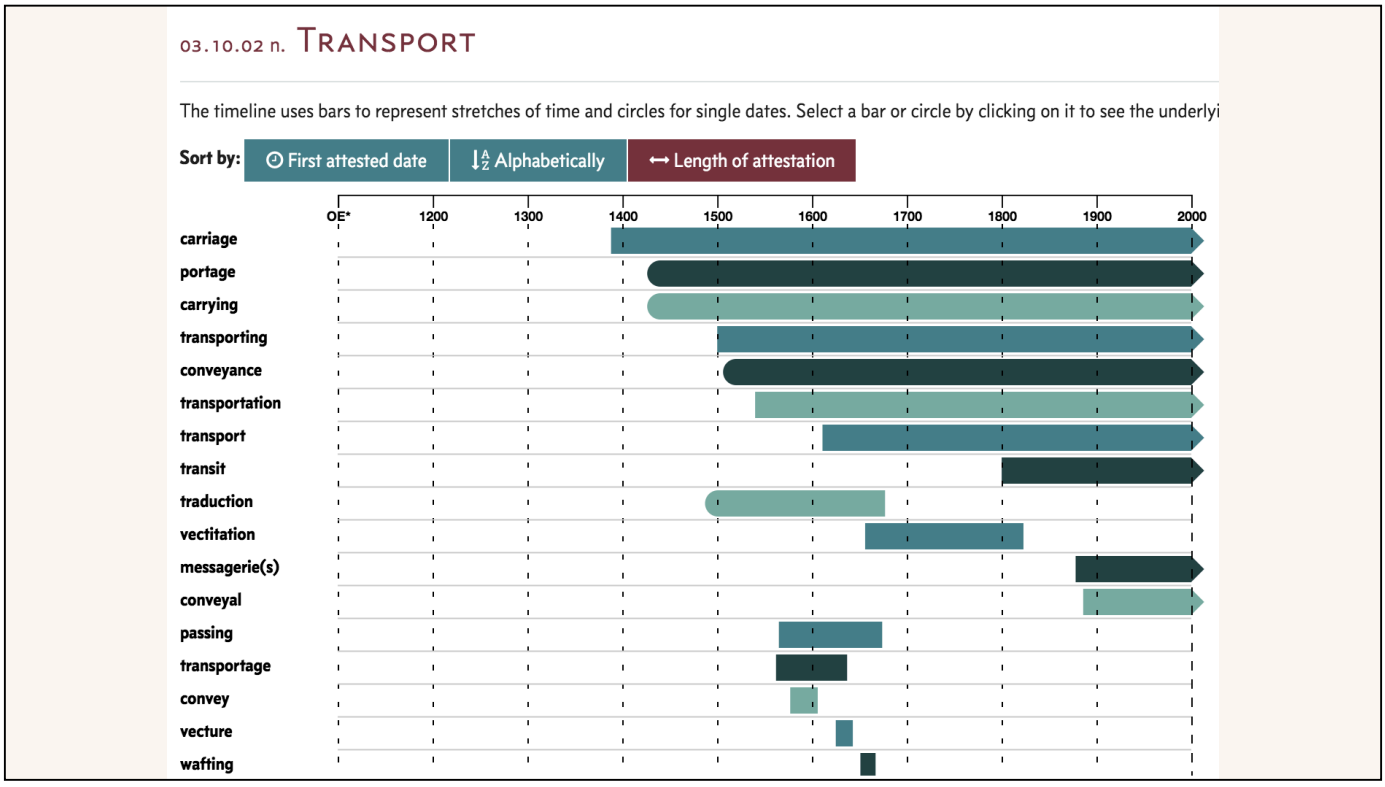
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03.10.02 Transport
03.10.03 Means of travel
03.10.04 Rail travel
03.10.05 Navigation
03.10.06 Air/space travel
03.10.06.01 Action of flying (in) aircraft
03.10.06.02 Specific movements/positions of aircraft
03.10.06.03 Transport by air
03.10.06.04 Regulation and control of flying
03.10.06.05 Airfield/airport
03.10.06.06 Gliding and hang-gliding
03.10.06.07 Ballooning
03.10.06.08 Parachuting
03.10.06.09 Use/science of rockets
03.10.06.10 Space flight
03.10.06.11 People who fly in aircraft/spacecraft
03.10.06.12 A means of conveyance through the air
03.10.06.12.01 Aeroplane
03.10.06.12.01.01 Qualities and parameters of aircraft
03.10.06.12.01.02 Parts of aircraft
03.10.06.12.01.02.01 Controls and instruments
03.10.06.12.01.02.02 Means of propulsion
03.10.06.12.02 Glider
03.10.06.12.03 Rotary wing aircraft
03.10.06.12.04 Balloons and airships
03.10.06.12.05 Kites
03.10.06.12.06 Parachute
03.10.06.12.07 Spacecraft
gas balloon 1881
01.01 TYPES OF BALLOON
Timeline
Cite
Montgolfier 1784/5–1866
fire-balloon 1822–
sausage 1858–
sausage balloon 1874–
hot-air balloon 1905–
observation balloon 1909–
01.01.01 ATTACHED TO A WIRE
kite-balloon 1898
sausage balloon 1916–1930 slang
02 AIRSHIP
ship 1679–
airship 1819–
dirigible 1885–
Zeppelin 1900–
aeronat 1903–1908
steerable 1908
vessel 1915–
zep(p) 1915– colloq.

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03.10.06.04 Regulation and control of flying
03.10.06.05 Airfield/airport
03.10.06.06 Gliding and hang-gliding
03.10.06.07 Ballooning
03.10.06.08 Parachuting
03.10.06.09 Use/science of rockets
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03.10.06.12.02 Glider
03.10.06.12.03 Rotary wing aircraft
03.10.06.12.04 Balloons and airships
03.10.06.12.05 Kites
03.10.06.12.06 Parachute
03.10.06.12.07 Spacecraft
03.10.06.12.07.01 Parts of spacecraft
03.10.06.12.07.02 Rocket
03.10.06.12.08 Construction and servicing aircraft/spacecraft
03.11 Occupation and work
03.12 Trade and finance
03.13 Leisure
hot-air balloon 1905–
observation balloon 1909–
01.01.01 ATTACHED TO A WIRE
Timeline
Cite
kite-balloon 1898
sausage balloon 1916–1930 slang
02 AIRSHIP
Timeline
Cite
ship 1679–
airship 1819–
dirigible 1885–
Zeppelin 1900–
aeronat 1903–1908
steerable 1908
vessel 1915–
zep(p) 1915– colloq.
02.01 TYPES OF AIRSHIP
Timeline
Cite
aeroplane 1884
non-rigid 1909
Parseval/Parsefal 1909–
blimp 1916–
submarine scout 1917–1954

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03.10.02 n. TRANSPORT
The timeline uses bars to represent stretches of time and circles for single dates. Select a bar or circle by clicking on it to see the underlyi
Sort by:
First attested date
Alphabetically
Length of attestation
OE*
1200
1300
1400
1500
1600
1700
1800
1900
2000
carriage
portage
carrying
transporting
conveyance
transportation
transport
transit
traduction
vectitation
messagerie(s)
conveyal
passing
transportage
convey
vecture
wafting

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Recent Language Change

- Punctuation becoming lexical items:
- 'Don't *at* me.'
  - I've spent countless dollars on cushions and pillows that didn't quite meet the approval of my neurotic hound mix, Leona, ending up shredded to pieces or, at best, ignored. Having a big pooch also means their furniture is going to be big, so you might as well pick an option or three (yes, Leona has three, don't at me) you don't hate looking at[...]
    Architectural Digest, 'The Best Dog Beds for Your Furry Best Friend', January 2024
- 'He's her boyfriend *slash* therapist'
  - One use: the first part intended versus the second part actual.
  - Another use: hesitation or blending. 'It's a library slash cafe', 'It's strawberry slash tangerine or something?'

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Follow-up

- As well as general reading from the reading list, you should have a look at chapters 4 and 5 from:
  - Kay, Christian & Kathryn Allan. 2015. *English Historical Semantics*. Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press. (As always, available as an ebook via the library.)
- If you have questions, talk to your tutor or do please come see me (email me for a time!)

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